어른과 밥 먹을 때: 한국의 식사 예절

A short guide to Korean table manners at meals with older people, with the polite phrases used before, during, and after eating.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

By the end, you can read simple Korean descriptions of table manners and find what to say and do at each point of a meal with older people.

1 THE FLOW OF A MEAL WITH OLDER PEOPLE

1. **어른이 먼저 앉기** (Let the oldest person sit first.)
2. **"잘 먹겠습니다"** (Say thanks before eating.)
3. **어른이 수저를 드신 뒤에 먹** (Start after the oldest person starts.)
4. **속도 맞추기** (Eat at the same pace as the others.)
5. **"잘 먹었습니다"** (Say thanks after eating.)

2 WORDS AND PHRASES AT THE TABLE

1. **잘 먹겠습니다** (thank you for the meal (before))
   Say it before you start eating, especially to the person who cooked or paid.
   예: 와, 맛있겠다! 잘 먹겠습니다.
2. **잘 먹었습니다** (thank you for the meal (after))
   Say it when you finish eating or when you leave.
   예: 부장님, 오늘 정말 잘 먹었습니다.
3. **맛있게 드세요** (enjoy your meal)
   Servers and hosts say this when they serve food.
   예: 음식 나왔습니다. 맛있게 드세요.
4. **많이 드세요** (please eat a lot)
   A host says this to make guests feel welcome.
   예: 차린 건 없지만 많이 드세요.
5. **수저를 들다** (to start eating)
   It means picking up the spoon and chopsticks to begin the meal.
   예: 할아버지께서 수저를 드신 다음에 먹기 시작했어요.
6. **속도를 맞추다** (to keep the same pace)
   Try not to finish much faster or slower than the older people at the table.
   예: 선배가 천천히 드셔서 저도 속도를 맞췄어요.
7. **두 손으로 받다** (to receive with both hands)
   Hold your glass or plate with both hands when an older person gives or pours something.
   예: 사장님이 따라 주신 술을 두 손으로 받았어요.
8. **고개를 돌리다** (to turn your head away)
   When you drink alcohol in front of an older person, turn your head a little to the side.
   예: 아버지 앞에서는 고개를 돌리고 한 잔 마셨어요.
9. **숟가락을 꽂다** (to stick a spoon upright)
   Do not leave a spoon standing in rice, because it reminds people of rites for the dead.
   예: 밥에 숟가락을 꽂아 두면 안 돼요.

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3 HOW IS IT DIFFERENT FROM YOUR COUNTRY?

Bowls stay on the table. In some countries, people lift the rice bowl to their mouth. In Korea, the rice bowl and soup bowl usually stay on the table. People eat rice and soup with a spoon and use chopsticks mostly for side dishes.
Pouring drinks: Many Koreans pour drinks for others, not for themselves. When an older person pours for you, hold your glass with both hands. When you pour for them, use both hands too, or support your pouring arm with your other hand.

These are common customs. Some families and younger groups are more relaxed, so watch what the people around you do.

4 YOUR TURN

USE THE MEAL MANNERS

Use the words, steps, and tips above to answer each question.

1 Is this good manners in Korea? Write Yes or No:
①회식에서 부장님이 수저를 드시기 전에 신입 사원이 먼저 먹기 시작했어요.
②할머니가 물을 따라 주셔서 컵을 두 손으로 잡았어요.
③장인어른 앞에서 술을 마실 때 고개를 살짝 옆으로 돌렸어요.

2 Choose the right expression:
①친구 어머니가 차려 주신 저녁을 다 먹고 일어날 때: (잘 먹겠습니다 / 잘 먹었습니다)
②집에 온 손님에게 음식을 내놓으면서: (많이 드세요 / 잘 먹겠습니다)

3 Fill in the blank with one word from "Words and phrases at the table":
교수님보다 너무 빨리 먹지 않으려고 식사 ____를 맞췄어요.

4 Choose the right word:
한국에서는 보통 밥을 (숟가락 / 젓가락)으로 먹어요.

5 Put the steps in order:
(가) 어른이 먼저 자리에 앉으시기를 기다리기 (나) “잘 먹었습니다”라고 인사하기 (다) “잘 먹겠습니다”라고 인사하기 (라) 어른과 속도를 맞춰 먹기

✓ ANSWERS

1) ① No ② Yes ③ Yes
2) ① 잘 먹었습니다 ② 많이 드세요
3) 속도
4) 숟가락
5) 가 → 다 → 라 → 나

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